Mars and Jupiter Are About to Meet in the Night Sky

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Look up on the night of November 15-16, and you will see two planets putting on a show. Mars and Jupiter will appear just over one degree apart in the **constellation** Leo, closer than they have been in years. They will not be this close again until July 2029.

The pair will rise over the eastern horizon around midnight for viewers in the United States. Below them, the blue-white star Regulus will glow. Mars will shine red, and Jupiter will shine bright beside it.

It is all a trick of perspective. In reality, Mars and Jupiter are separated by more than 368 million miles. The light from Regulus has traveled about 79 **light-years** to reach Earth. The planets only look close because they line up from our viewpoint.

Astronomers call this kind of meeting an **appulse**. It happens about once every two to two and a half years, when Mars catches up to Jupiter as the two planets travel around the sun. Jupiter is farther out, so Mars, moving on its closer, faster path, laps it from time to time.

Both Mars and Jupiter are what astronomers call **superior planets**, meaning their orbits lie beyond Earth's. Through a telescope, their disks always look full. Mercury and Venus, which orbit closer to the sun than Earth, show moon-like phases instead.

A six-inch telescope can show how different the two worlds are. Jupiter's giant bands of cloud ring the gas giant, made of ammonia and water moving in different directions through its hydrogen and helium air, pushed by powerful jet streams. Mars looks like a reddish, **ochre** disk with dark patches, where basalt rock has been swept clean of the iron-rich dust that covers much of its surface.

Word Treasure

constellation -- A group of stars that forms a picture in the sky.
appulse -- When two planets appear very close together in the sky.
superior planets -- Planets whose orbits lie farther from the sun than Earth's.
light-years -- The distance light travels in one year, used to measure space.
ochre -- A yellow-brown color, like the color of Mars.

Background you need

The sun is the star at the center of our solar system, and the planets travel around it.

Mars is a cold, rocky world that looks red because of iron-rich dust.

Jupiter is a giant ball of gas.

A telescope is a tool that makes faraway things in the sky look bigger and closer.

Break it down

LEAD: Mars and Jupiter will appear side by side in the night sky on November 15-16.
KEY EVENT: The two planets meet in the constellation Leo.
+- WHO: Mars, Jupiter, and the star Regulus
+- WHEN: The night of November 15-16, rising around midnight
+- WHERE: In the eastern sky, in the constellation Leo
EVIDENCE: The planets are really more than 368 million miles apart; the meeting happens every two to two and a half years.
OPEN QUESTION: The article leaves none; it ends with what a telescope can show of the two planets.

Why it matters

Watching planets meet in the sky is a chance to see how the solar system moves, and it can turn anyone into a skywatcher for a night. Events like this happen only every few years, so they are worth stepping outside for.

Test what you remember

1. When will Mars and Jupiter appear close together?

- (A) On Christmas Day
- (B) On July 4
- (C) On the night of November 15-16
- (D) Next summer

2. When will they be this close again?

- (A) In 2027
- (B) July 2029
- (C) Never again
- (D) Next month

3. How far apart are Mars and Jupiter really?

- (A) 170 miles
- (B) More than 368 million miles
- (C) One degree
- (D) 79 light-years

4. What is the meeting of two planets called?

- (A) A comet
- (B) An appulse
- (C) An eclipse
- (D) A meteor

5. What does the star Regulus look like?

- (A) Green
- (B) Blue-white
- (C) Red
- (D) Yellow

6. What can a six-inch telescope show on Jupiter?

- (A) Its oceans
- (B) Giant bands of cloud
- (C) Its rocky surface
- (D) Its moons' names

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: B 3: B 4: B 5: B 6: B

Questions to think about

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):